will separate out, joining those dominant since 1945. This is still work in progress, one could even say in the early stages. Much will increasingly depend on how and with what agenda combinations of states come together.

Technology, too, has become more of a game-changer than in the past. Its ability to impact the daily routine is much deeper, as indeed the capability to weaponize our normal activities, needs and resources. In fact, the pace has reached a point where we are compelled to think in terms of ‘techades’. And then there are the perennial games that nations play, expressed through competitive politics between individual countries or, sometimes, groupings. Each of these phenomena is a key factor in the fashioning of contemporary Indian foreign policy, individually as much as cumulatively. Today, India has to not just prepare for a re-globalization that corrects economic and technology concentrations but also use that opportunity to strengthen comprehensive national power.

Given that there is at least as much change as there is continuity in world politics, it is obvious that our approach cannot be overly reliant on muscle memory. Certainly, the structural framework and previous experiences have a critical bearing. But, at the same time, the processes described above that are continually shaping our current existence need to be given full recognition. There are important shifts in power between and within states that are also relevant to the overall calculation. Much of that centres on the US, whose dominance is clearly not what it was in the past. That it has changed is indisputable; what it leads to will be still very much a matter of debate. And recent events have demonstrated that neither its capabilities nor its influence should be underestimated. Reading its new posture right is a challenge in itself, especially when it exercises influence in a more off-shore manner. How invested it is in various regions is a natural question, one juxtaposed against the growing presence of other nations, especially China.

Political polarization within societies is also a factor that the diplomacy of many states needs to take into account. Domestic changes, in the US as much as China, are compelling some countries to recalibrate their posture accordingly. As geopolitical arenas go, a world long used to thinking of West Asia and Europe as the central theatres of competition is increasingly looking at the Indo-Pacific instead. Even distant countries are, therefore, compelled to come up with their respective Indo-Pacific approaches. The